OXFORD SAÏD AI TOOLKIT

Assessment design: 10 practical checklists

Review your assessment and adapt the wording for your students.

Choose the checklist for your assessment type. Complete the brackets and check the wording against approved local requirements before use. These are Toolkit suggestions, not University policy.

Find your checklist: exams and essays (p. 1); literature reviews, case studies, presentations and group projects (p. 2); quantitative work, coding, dissertations and AI-integral tasks (p. 3). Shared design checks and guidance follow on pp. 4–5.

1 Timed exams and in-class tests

- ☐ Define whether the task tests recall, method, reasoning, interpretation or application.
- ☐ Use approved controlled conditions and explain why AI is not authorised, if that is the decision.
- ☐ Require workings, justification or application rather than final answers alone.
- ☐ Check accessibility, reasonable adjustments, time pressure and platform reliability.
- ☐ Rotate or refresh questions for assessment quality, not because novelty makes them inaccessible to AI.

Adaptable wording

AI use is not authorised in this assessment because independent performance under controlled conditions is part of the capability being assessed. [State any authorised assistive technology or reasonable-adjustment arrangements.]

2 Take-home essays

- ☐ State the argument, synthesis or disciplinary judgement the essay should evidence.
- ☐ Choose the AI-use category before deciding whether drafts, plans or reflections are needed.
- ☐ Use specific course material, comparison, application or a justified critical position.
- ☐ Ask for proportionate process evidence only when it contributes to learning or assessment validity.
- ☐ Align criteria with reasoning, evidence and judgement rather than presentation alone.

Adaptable wording

AI may be used only for [permitted tasks]. It must not be used to [excluded tasks]. Your final argument, interpretation and use of evidence must be your own. Include the declaration in the location and form prescribed for this assessment.

Checklists 3–6

3 Literature reviews

- ☐ Decide whether literature discovery, screening, synthesis or writing is being assessed.
- ☐ Require a transparent search strategy appropriate to the discipline.
- ☐ Ask students to verify every AI-suggested source against the original record.
- ☐ Use annotated source notes or inclusion and exclusion reasoning where these evidence the learning outcome.
- ☐ Mark synthesis, evaluation and judgement, not the number of sources found.

Adaptable wording

Where AI is used for literature discovery or organisation, verify each source against the original publication and declare the tool, purpose and verification process. AI-generated citations must not be treated as verified sources.

4 Case studies and policy memos

- ☐ Clarify whether the task tests diagnosis, recommendation, trade-offs, evidence use or communication to an audience.
- ☐ Use supplied data and a specific decision context rather than relying on novelty or secrecy.
- ☐ Require a prioritised recommendation and explicit reasoning.
- ☐ Make assumptions, limitations and trade-offs visible.
- ☐ Use an oral or written defence only where proportionate and consistently designed.

Adaptable wording

Your recommendation must be justified using the supplied evidence and explicit trade-offs. AI may be used for [tasks], but you remain responsible for the analysis, source verification and final recommendation.

5 Presentations and posters

- ☐ Decide whether the assessment tests content, communication, visual design, oral response or all four.
- ☐ State whether AI may support research, scripting, slide design or rehearsal.
- ☐ Use individual questioning or explanation where it is part of the intended learning.
- ☐ Provide consistent criteria and reasonable adjustments for any live component.
- ☐ For groups, include a contribution statement and an individual evidence component where appropriate.

Adaptable wording

AI may be used for [preparation tasks]. It may not be used during the live assessed component unless explicitly stated. Be prepared to explain the evidence, choices and recommendations in your presentation.

6 Group projects

- ☐ Separate the team product from the individual learning that needs to be evidenced.
- ☐ Use milestone decisions, role records or contribution statements proportionately.
- ☐ Specify whether the AI-use instructions apply to the team, each member or both.
- ☐ Avoid process logging that creates excessive surveillance or workload.
- ☐ Use peer or individual evidence with transparent criteria.

Adaptable wording

Where required by the approved group-assessment instructions, submit [team / individual] contribution statements. Follow the prescribed AI-use declaration format and the published rules for individual and group assessment.

Checklists 7–10

7 Problem sets and quantitative work

- ☐ Identify whether the learning lies in method selection, calculation, interpretation or modelling judgement.
- ☐ Require workings and conceptual explanation where they provide relevant evidence.
- ☐ Decide whether AI may check, generate or explain code and calculations.
- ☐ Use parameter variation for breadth and feedback, not as a guarantee against AI use.
- ☐ Mark method, assumptions, error checking and interpretation.

Adaptable wording

AI may be used for [checking / formatting / debugging] but not to generate the submitted solution. Show your workings and explain why the selected method is appropriate. Declare AI use in the format prescribed for this assessment.

8 Coding and data analysis

- ☐ Decide whether syntax, architecture, debugging, analysis, interpretation or professional use of AI is being assessed.
- ☐ Require explanation of key design and analytical choices.
- ☐ Use version history, notebooks or demonstrations where they support the learning outcome.
- ☐ Require the prescribed AI-use declaration; add code comments where the instructions also require them.
- ☐ Mark understanding, testing, reproducibility, limitations and interpretation.

Adaptable wording

AI coding tools may be used for [permitted tasks]. You must understand, test and be able to explain all submitted code. Use the prescribed AI-use declaration. Identify AI-generated or modified code and explain verification as the instructions require.

9 Research proposals and dissertations

- ☐ Define permitted AI use by stage: question development, literature work, methods, analysis, drafting and editing.
- ☐ Use supervision and milestones as developmental evidence, not forensic proof.
- ☐ Apply both the assessment instructions and the University research policy where relevant.
- ☐ Address data protection, confidentiality, ethics, intellectual property, funder and publisher rules.
- ☐ Require a declaration in the location and form prescribed locally.

Adaptable wording

AI use is governed by the written assessment instructions, the University research policy where applicable and local departmental requirements. Use the prescribed assessment declaration and meet any additional research disclosure requirements. Verify outputs and remain responsible for the final work.

10 AI-integral critique or simulation

- ☐ Make the AI-related capability an explicit learning outcome.
- ☐ Ensure equal baseline tool provision. Any alternative must be approved, accessible and equivalent for the intended learning.
- ☐ Assess prompting only where it is pedagogically relevant; prioritise evaluation and judgement.
- ☐ Require verification against disciplinary sources and identification of limitations.
- ☐ Plan for tool failure, model variation and accessibility.

Adaptable wording

Use of [tool or capability] is required for this assessment. Your marks will be based on how well you evaluate, verify, improve and take responsibility for the output, not on the fluency of the AI-generated content alone.

Review the whole design

> ## Make student learning and judgement visible.
>
> The central question is not simply “Did AI write this?” but whether the assessment provides credible evidence that the student can reach a reasoned conclusion and explain, defend and apply it. Keeping an existing assessment unchanged is a legitimate outcome when it already does this.

The five-step workflow

1 Clarify the purpose

State the knowledge, reasoning, judgement, performance or professional capability the assessment should evidence.

2 Choose the AI-use category

Decide whether AI use is not authorised, selective use authorised or integral use required, and describe the tasks any selective use covers. These are illustrative labels, not mandatory University categories. Use any categories your department or programme has formally adopted.

3 Check the evidence

Ask whether, under that category, the work will still give sufficient evidence of the intended learning. Keeping the assessment as it is can be the right answer. Check validity, inclusion, visible evidence of learning and clear responsibilities.

4 Write the instructions and declaration

Issue clear written guidance in advance for each summative assessment. Specify permitted, required and excluded uses and the declaration expected, using any format your department prescribes.

5 Mark, review and improve

Apply the approved marking criteria, review the assessment after use and update the design through the usual approval route when evidence, student experience or technology changes.

Before the assessment is issued

Seven statements that should be true before the assessment is issued.

- The intended learning and the reason for the AI-use category are explicit.
- Students receive written guidance before the assessment and know what to declare.
- Appropriate permitted tools have equal baseline provision; any alternative is approved and avoids disadvantage.
- The design is accessible, proportionate and manageable for students, markers and administrators.
- Approved marking criteria reward the intended knowledge, reasoning, judgement or performance.
- No claim is made that a format, process record or oral component proves authorship or is AI-proof.
- The design has the necessary local approval and fits Examination Regulations and programme requirements.

AI-use categories and safeguards

Categories are a shared language, not an assessment design. Their value depends on alignment with the intended learning, disciplinary context, equitable access, staff capacity, marking and workable implementation. The University policy does not prescribe named categories; formally adopted local categories take precedence.

Not authorised

Examples: Closed exam; unaided calculation; live performance.

Use it when: Independent performance is itself the capability being assessed.

What students need: A clear statement, and which assistive technology or reasonable adjustments are covered.

Selective use authorised: Specific listed tasks

Examples: Proofreading; finding sources; checking code.

Use it when: Specific support can assist without replacing the intended learning.

What students need: An explicit list of permitted and excluded tasks, and the declaration format.

Selective use authorised: Wider use within stated limits

Examples: Take-home analysis with source checking.

Use it when: AI may support broad parts of the process, but the student remains responsible for judgement and evidence.

What students need: The limits, what must be verified and the declaration format.

Integral use required

Examples: Audit, compare or improve AI output.

Use it when: Using and evaluating AI is part of the learning outcome.

What students need: The required tool, equal baseline access, safeguards and the declaration format.

Implementation safeguards

Process evidence is evidence, not proof of authorship. Oral follow-up is not a universal gold standard.

Where AI could materially obscure the capability being assessed, draw on more than one proportionate source of evidence, such as the submitted work together with staged drafts, explanation or dialogue. No single component proves authorship.

Any oral or additional component that affects marks should be specified in advance, consistently applied, accessible, proportionate and locally approved. Do not add an unapproved oral assessment selectively in response to suspicion. Follow the applicable misconduct procedure, which may include authorised individual questioning.

Status and scope

This is practical guidance developed at Saïd Business School for local academic discussion. It is not University policy and has not been formally endorsed. It supports, and does not replace, the University policy on AI use in summative assessment, Examination Regulations, local approval processes, accessibility requirements and programme guidance.

Use it to move from the intended learning to a clear AI-use category, evidence of student learning and adaptable assessment wording. It covers common assessment types rather than prescribing one University-wide design.

Official sources

- University policy: AI use in summative assessment
- Generative AI at Oxford
- Centre for Teaching and Learning: AI in teaching and learning
- CTL briefing note on AI-use categories: OxIntranet (Oxford sign-in)